



ShabbaTTogether

Shalom Zone Guide for Ages 5-12

Goal: To create a quiet/calm down space in your home for all ages to use to help regulate strong emotions in a healthy way.

Target Audience: Children ages 5-12

Time: Approximately 1 hour to create or more if you want to be creative

Medium: @Home project

Note to Parents

Dear Parents,

This information is for you on how to create a Shalom Zone together with your child in your home. Included are items to print, color and hang, items to purchase or make on your own, and different tools to help make your Shalom Zone a useful tool for your needs.

Enjoy!

What is a Shalom Zone?

Sometimes winding down can be hard for kids, especially with all of the distractions around like games, siblings, TV, internet, etc. Creating a quiet corner or a reading nook can give children a wonderful opportunity to find calm (and you too!).

The Shalom Zone is a safe space for kids to go when they need help self-regulating or calming their bodies and emotions. It is meant to be a place for them to relax, recharge, or release their pent-up anger or frustration.

Picking The Right Space For The Shalom Zone

Try to pick one space in your home for your child's Shalom Zone area so that they know exactly where to go when they need it.

It should be away from distractions and can really be anywhere you want: in your child's bedroom, in the basement, under the stairs, in a closet, in a corner of a room — wherever you think your child will be the most comfortable!

When To Use The Shalom Zone

The Shalom Zone space should feel welcoming and inviting to your child. Please keep in mind however, it is not designed as a place to send your child for punishment or a time-out so do not force them to use the space in that way.

You can use the calm Shalom Zone right after school or before bed to help kids unwind and decompress after a long day. Retreating to a calm down space is perfect for when your child is angry, frustrated, anxious, or overwhelmed. It can also help when they are having a tantrum or meltdown.

Introduce the Shalom Zone to your child prior to using it, when they are calm and relaxed. Let them know that it is their special place to go when they need some time to themselves and that you may remind them of their special Shalom Zone when they seem to need it.

Watch your child's body and behaviour for signs that they might be overwhelmed and need a break. If you can see that your child is struggling to self-regulate, then simply validate their feelings and emotions and suggest that they enjoy some quiet time in their Shalom Zone. You can also suggest sitting with them and reading a book or sitting together as a way to invite them into their assigned space.

What To Include In Your Shalom Zone

When it comes to deciding what to include in your child's Shalom Zone, try to involve them in the decisions so they feel ownership over their space. Since each child is different, consider your child's interests when setting up the space. Use objects that your child finds comforting, engaging, and calming. Keep items age appropriate and ask older children to be more involved in helping to create the space.

Here are some examples of items to consider including in your Shalom Zone:

- Printable Signs to Print and Hang:
 - ○ A [“My Shalom Zone”](#) sign that your child designs and can hang in their space
 - Emotional Regulation Chart - [What Zone Am I In?](#)
- A comfy place to sit like a bean bag, some pillows, or a play tent
- A journal to document your journey or get out your emotions
- A sketchbook to express your feelings or relax through art
- Lego
- [Fidget toys to spin, twist and manipulate](#)
- Art supplies and/or sticker books
- [Weighted Blanket](#)
- Puzzles
- [One Person card games](#)
- Noise-reducing headphones to block out sounds that are overwhelming
- [Chewy jewelry and toys](#)
- Stress balls to squeeze or [make your own!](#)
- A favorite stuffed animal to hug
- [Something visual like a sensory bottle, kaleidoscope or lava lamp](#) or [make your own!](#)
- Engaging one-person activities like activity books, individual board games, building blocks, drawing books or magnet tiles.